

Gaza medical evacuees enter Egypt

Thousands of Palestinian patients hope to use reopened border crossing.

By SAMY MAGDY
AND JOSEF FEDERMAN

CAIRO — A small number of medical evacuees from Gaza entered Egypt on Monday as the Rafah border crossing reopened, marking a key step in the Israel-Hamas ceasefire but a mostly symbolic one. Few people will be allowed to travel in either direction and no goods will pass through.

About 20,000 Palestinian children and adults needing medical care hope to leave the devastated territory via the crossing, according to Gaza health officials. Thousands of other Palestinians outside the territory hope to enter and return home.

The crossing had been closed since Israeli troops seized it in May 2024. The number of travelers is expected to increase over time if the system is successful. Israel said it and Egypt will vet people for exit and entry.

Ambulances waited for hours at the border before ferrying patients into Egypt, the state-run Al-Qahera News satellite television channel showed. The office of the North Sinai governor confirmed that the first Palestinian patient crossed.

It was unclear if anyone had been allowed into Gaza.

Before the war, Rafah was the main crossing for people moving in and out of Gaza. The territory's other crossings are all shared with Israel. Under the terms of the ceasefire, which went into effect in October, Israel's military controls the area between the Rafah [See Patients, A3]

Why L.A. paid \$3.25 million for a dog bite

By SANDRA McDONALD

In the video, a gray pit bull named Valerio stood on a woman's lap, furiously wagging his tail as he accepted her caresses.

"I'm the best boy ever! I love to play. I love snuggling and I'll let you put silly costumes on me," said the caption on the Feb. 14, 2022, Instagram post.

Kristin Wright responded: "I work so it's a little crazy. Can Valerio just get in the back seat of my car."

That August, two days after Wright adopted 4-year-old Valerio from the city animal shelter in South Los Angeles, he attacked her, breaking her right arm and peeling skin off her left arm.

Only later did Wright discover that Valerio was surrendered to the shelter after biting his previous owner's elderly mother in the face.

Wright and her husband sued the city, reaching a \$3.25-million settlement in November.

Wright, 75, said she never would have adopted Valerio had she known of his violent history. After multiple surgeries, she still has nerve damage and pain in her fingers and hands, making it difficult for her to do her work as an accountant.

"They made a choice [to adopt Valerio out], and now I have to live my life like this," she said.

Jenna Edzant, one of Wright's lawyers who has [See Shelter, A14]



A U.N. vehicle escorts a bus carrying Palestinian patients in Khan Yunis, Gaza Strip, to the Rafah crossing.

ABDEL KAREEM HANA Associated Press

Trump calls Kennedy Center ‘dilapidated,’ says he’ll remake it

Less than a year after taking over the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts and appointing himself chairman, President Trump has announced that the venue will shut down for two years, beginning July 4, to undergo a major renovation.

"This important decision ... will take a tired, broken, and dilapidated Center, one that has been in bad condition, both financially and structurally for many years, and turn it into a World Class Bastion of Arts, Music and Entertainment, far better than it has ever been before," Trump wrote Sunday on his social media website.

Sen. Sheldon Whitehouse (D-R.I.),

Senator says the planned two-year closure and renovation are meant to cover up president’s failures

By Jessica Gelt

who serves as an ex officio member of the center's board of trustees, condemned Trump's decision to close the venue in a statement issued early Monday.

"As President Trump continues his demolition tour of Washington, he's now setting his sights on one of America's great cultural institutions," Whitehouse said. "And yet again, he's bucking rules and convention to do so. If he succeeds, it will be because of a series of suspect and illegal actions to commandeer the Kennedy Center as a clubhouse for his friends and political allies and install leadership who will [See Center, A14]

Callers connecting across party lines

California liberals, conservative Texans find common ground on phone



LOGAN IVEY Matter Neuroscience
A RED "Call a Republican" public phone was set up in San Francisco.

By CLARA HARTER

A rather peculiar red public phone appeared outside a San Francisco tattoo parlor last month, urging residents in one of America's most liberal cities to "call a Republican."

Its counterpart, a blue phone, sits outside a bookshop in the staunchly conservative town of Abilene, Texas, where it encourages locals to "call a Democrat."

Together, the phones form a social experiment: When someone picks up the line in San Francisco, it rings in Texas, and vice versa, cultivating a unique opportunity for passersby to chat with a stranger who holds a vastly different outlook on politics and life.

The initiative, dubbed the Party Line project, is the brainchild of Matter Neuroscience, a mental health startup focused on researching the science be-

hind happiness and creating tools to battle major depressive disorders.

Neuroscientists know that fighting with people who hold different views leads to the release of cortisol in the brain, which increases stress, Matter co-founder Ben Goldhirsh explained. On the other hand, engaging in non-hateful, human-to-human conversation activates happiness-boosting neurotransmitters such as dopamine and cannabinoids, he said.

"We wanted to see what would happen when people had the chance to connect with people directly — would they choose to argue and fight, or would they choose to find common ground?" Goldhirsh said. "[Would they choose] the release of cortisol or the release of cannabinoids?"

Much to researchers' delight, the vast majority of callers have chosen to seek common ground. The project [See Public phones, A6]

An oasis of freshness in an L.A. food desert

Hyde Park hub is helping Black farmers bring produce to market

By Jenn Harris



RONALDO BOLANOS Los Angeles Times

IMANI DIGGS of Imani Gardens sells a variety of fruits from his storefront at the Crenshaw Food Hub.

Finding ways around Newsom legacy

What Democrats in governor's race would do differently from popular incumbent.

By NICOLE NIXON

SACRAMENTO — Matt Mahan, the mayor of San José and latest entrant into the jam-packed race for California governor, has in recent years raised his profile outside his Silicon Valley-area city by doing something most other elected Democrats would never: publicly criticize Gov. Gavin Newsom.

With the primary election almost four months away, candidates have already been busy trying to convince Californians that they can lead the state through its biggest challenges, including what they might do differently than Newsom on homelessness, crime and the high cost of living.

Democratic hopefuls have done so subtly, without taking direct shots at Newsom.

Until Mahan entered the race.

The 43-year-old mayor began carving a moderate path in 2024, when he broke with Newsom and other Democrats to back Proposition 36, which increased penalties for theft and crimes involving fentanyl. Despite opposition from Newsom and legislative leaders, voters overwhelmingly approved it.

Mahan has also given mixed reviews to the Newsom administration's approach to homelessness; he has praised efforts to make it easier for cities to clear homeless encampments but criticized inconsistent funding from the state to help local governments build interim housing.

Although most Democrats running to replace Newsom have praised his fiery opposition to President Trump and the Republican-led Congress, including the governor's outlandish online trolling of Trump and his allies, Mahan was not impressed.

"Instead of spending so much energy attacking his opponents, the governor and his team should be addressing the high cost of energy, helping hard-pressed families make ends meet and keeping them and their employers from fleeing our state," Mahan wrote last summer in a piece for the [See Governor, A6]

years he has delivered watermelons to Las Vegas and all over California, including Richmond, Woodland Hills and Orange County. Now he's selling watermelons, juice and other produce from his first storefront, called Imani Gardens, inside the Crenshaw Food Hub.

The new food hub has taken over the space formerly occupied by Kathy's Kitchen. Kathy Alston opened her tiny juice shop in 2020, selling produce and making juice from whatever she sourced from farmers markets around the city. But after five years in the space, Alston made the difficult decision to close.

"I always had a dream of just bringing healthier food options to the community," she said. "I started Kathy's Kitchen to realize that dream, and I did all I could do."

Now, Diggs and his partners Adam X and former Compton Community Garden director TemuAsyr Martin Bey are continuing Alston's dream, but on a much grander scale.

Diggs and X spent the last couple of years hosting [See Food hub, A7]

Southland sees summerlike heat

Southern California experiences a midwinter heat wave as parts of the United States freeze. CALIFORNIA, B1

The Grammys' timeless rhythm

History-making award winners create music rooted in tradition and speak to the present. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Knight grows women's hockey

Decorated Olympian a tireless promoter for her sport as she goes for fifth medal in Winter Games. SPORTS, B10

Weather

Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 81/57. B6

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